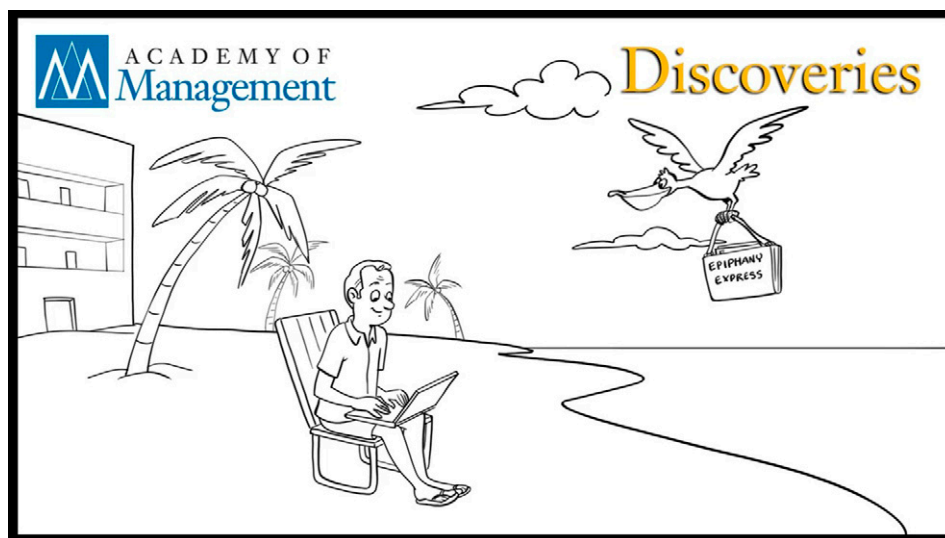


SUDDENLY EVERYTHING BECAME CLEAR: HOW PEOPLE MAKE SENSE OF EPIPHANIES SURROUNDING THEIR WORK AND CAREERS

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Although it is widely recognized that many psychological phenomena, such as “insight,” are grounded in nonconscious processing, the manner in which people make sense of these phenomena remains enigmatic. Through the research reported here, I developed theory in this area by exploring how people make sense of a particular form of insight: self-referential insights—or *epiphanies*—concerning their work or career. My findings indicate that although people view their epiphanies as having played a critical role in resolving psychological tension they once faced, the cognitive operations underlying epiphanies are so inscrutable that people ultimately focus their accounts on the conditions in which they believe their epiphanies were born. As these accounts reveal, people are inclined to attribute their epiphanies to serendipitous circumstances. At the same time, people believe their epiphanies came about because they were open to the possibility of being transformed and attuned to events that could help trigger this transformation. These findings provide cause to rethink assumptions in the field of management underlying research on interpretation and attribution and illuminate the potentially critical, although undertheorized, role of “readiness” in fostering epiphanies and solving problems at work.

I have a three-by-five up there with this fragment of a sentence from a story by Chekhov: “. . .and suddenly everything became clear to him.” I find these words filled with wonder and possibility. I love their simple clarity, and the hint of revelation that’s implied. There is mystery too. Why is it just now becoming clear? What’s happened? (Carver, 1985: 47)

I thank Kevin Corley, Jennifer Petriglieri, and Scott Sonenshein for their feedback on earlier versions of this manuscript.

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A sizable body of research in the organizational and psychological sciences indicates that, as humans, we often lack a window into our own mental processes (Bargh & Chartrand, 1999; George, 2009; Wilson, 2002). In part, this is because a good deal of our thinking occurs through processes that cannot be consciously and comprehensively observed and reported (Dijksterhuis & Nordgren, 2006; Evans, 2008; Pratt & Crosina, 2016). The fact that many psychological processes occur outside our awareness is not necessarily problematic—and indeed may be adaptive (Hofmann & Wilson, 2010). Even so, the ineffability of the events unfolding in the nonconscious realm poses

mysteries to those receiving their byproducts. *Where did that feeling come from? Why did that solution pop into my head? How is it that, all of a sudden, I feel ready to change careers?*

A paradigmatic phenomenon in this regard is an “Aha!” moment—or the experience of “insight” (Chu & MacGregor, 2011). An insight occurs when one’s mental representation of a particular problem, tension, or situation is suddenly transformed, such that one perceives the target through a new and useful light (Kounios & Beeman, 2014). Just as the annals of scientific discovery are flush with cases in which solutions to vexing problems emerged in a flash (Bowden, Jung-Beeman, Fleck, & Kounios, 2005), so too do entrepreneurs and organizational executives credit insights they experienced as keys to their success (Sawhney & Khosla, 2014). Although researchers have posed a range of explanations for how insights arise (e.g., Hélie & Sun, 2010; Kounios & Beeman, 2009; MacGregor, Ormerod, & Chronicle, 2001), the fact that insights emerge suddenly, often with surprise, is consistent with the view that insights are fostered through nonconscious thought (Kounios & Beeman, 2014; Sio & Ormerod, 2009).

In an economy privileging problem-solving and knowledge creation, it is perhaps not surprising that the phenomenon of insight has attracted the attention of organizational scholars (e.g., Cronin, 2004; Maddux, Adam, & Galinsky, 2010; Zhang, Gino, & Margolis, 2018). Nevertheless, as in psychology, interest in insight in the fields of management and organization studies has generally been limited to what insight is and how it occurs. Although such research has substantially deepened our understanding of this phenomenon, research on insight has broadly overlooked a key question. Namely, how do people account for—or make sense of—their own insights?

Through the research reported here, I explored this question. In doing so, I investigated how people make sense of what I conceptualize as a particular form of insight—an *epiphany*. Like many terms used by scholars and throughout society, the term epiphany has been used in a variety of ways. In some cases, the term has been used synonymously with insight itself (van Iterson, Clegg, & Carlsen, 2017). For example, some have characterized an epiphany as “a showing forth, an illumination” (Beja, 1971: 15) and, similarly, as “a sudden recognition or insight into the

essential meaning of something” (Jauregui, 2007: xxv). By this standard, an insight-based solution to a work-related task or problem may be aptly described as an epiphany. That said, others have depicted epiphanies as a more specialized form of an insight—one relevant in some way to one’s self-concept (e.g., Bien, 2004; McAdams, 1996; McDonald, 2008; Miller, 2004). For example, McAdams (1996: 309) characterized an epiphany as “a particular event . . . through which the Me experienced rather sudden or decided transformation.” Viewed from this perspective, an epiphany signifies a self-referential insight.

Because self-referential insights are likely to be vivid and impactful, people may be especially inclined toward recalling and detailing insights of this nature. Consequently, in building theory on how people make sense of their insights, I adopted an “extreme case” approach (see Pratt, 2009) by focusing on insights relevant to and reflective of one’s sense of self. Consistent with this methodological approach—and for the sake of conceptual clarity—in this article, I use the term epiphany in line with its more specialized conceptualization, namely, as a self-referential insight.

The inductive research reported here is concerned with understanding how people make sense of epiphanies surrounding their work and careers.² As recent scholarship suggests, nonconscious processes in general and insights and epiphanies more specifically play key roles in shaping how people engage with organizational and professional challenges (Pratt & Crosina, 2016; van Iterson et al., 2017). My focus on work- and career-related epiphanies is intended to advance theory in this regard. With that said, my findings may be generalizable to how people make sense of epiphanies that are not work related—and a number of observations advanced here align with this possibility.

In building theory on how people interpret, account for, and draw meaning from epiphanies of relevance to their work or career, my research contributes to extant theory in several ways. To begin, although scholars have observed that people’s

² As used here, the expression “how people make sense” is not equivalent to the concept of *sensemaking* (cf. Weick, 1995). Although sensemaking encompasses interpretation (a phenomenon relevant to the present article), it is not limited to it; rather, sensemaking also implicates behavioral responses (“enactment”) and often occurs through social processes (Maitlis & Christianson, 2014). My use of “making sense” matches what Maitlis and Christianson view as “the more colloquial use of the sensemaking term”—a use “synonymous with ‘trying to understand’, ‘thinking about’, or ‘socially constructing’ issues or situations” (2014: 60).

Author’s voice:

What motivated you to undertake this study?



explanations of their own mental processes can, in some cases, be incomplete or contrived (Nisbett & Wilson, 1977), people's theories in this regard are not without consequences. My findings illustrate this critical point by suggesting that, in large part, the power of an epiphany lies in how people believe it came to arise.

More specifically, my findings indicate that people's accounts of their epiphanies differ from the types of attributions commonly witnessed in people's accounts of personally meaningful events. In contrast to research suggesting that, particularly in Western societies, people tend to assign themselves undue credit for favorable events (Mezulis, Abramson, Hyde, & Hankin, 2004), my research shows that people are generally reluctant to take credit for their epiphanies. That is, although epiphanies are, at their core, a psychological phenomenon, people are inclined to attribute their epiphanies primarily to forces beyond themselves. This attribution leads people to perceive their epiphanies as products of good fortune; they feel lucky that such experiences occurred in their lives. As I later discuss, attributing epiphanies to good fortune heightens an epiphany's resonance and contributes to the enduring influence of epiphanies on personal change.

At the same time, my findings show that people believe their epiphanies occurred not only because of serendipitous circumstances but also because they were open to the prospect of experiencing an epiphany and sufficiently attuned to events that could help produce one. This raises the possibility that although people tend to downplay the role they played in formulating their epiphanies, people may, to some degree, be able to cultivate epiphanies proactively. That is, by achieving a state of "readiness," a concept central to my findings, one may set the stage for an epiphany to occur. This observation points toward a noteworthy, yet theoretically underdeveloped, possibility related to epiphanies, insights, and problem-solving as a whole. Namely, in some cases, the barriers toward solving a given problem are not limited to challenges inherent to the problem itself. Rather, people may not be able to solve certain problems until they are ready to accept the personally meaningful consequences of reaching a solution and to perceive events in a solution-producing manner.

In sum, the research reported here demonstrates how people make sense of their work- and career-related epiphanies, provides cause to reconsider certain assumptions in the literature on managerial cognition, and opens new windows into when and why people are able to generate epiphanies and insights more generally. Building toward these contributions, I begin with a conceptual overview of

insights and epiphanies. I then detail my research methodology and findings and conclude by discussing the implications and future research directions associated with this project.

INSIGHTS AND EPIPHANIES

As discussed in previous research, insights are demarcated by specific features (for a review, see Kounios & Beeman, 2014). They occur suddenly, often after one has reached an impasse. They involve a shift or alteration of how one has previously conceived of the problem. They transform a situation marked by confusion and opacity to one of clarity.

Researchers have advanced a variety of explanations for how insights arise. Most explanations pose a role for *incubation*—a period of time in which one's attention "shift[s] away from an unsolved problem that allows a solution to emerge seemingly as if from no additional effort" (Sio & Ormerod, 2009: 94). What, exactly, happens during the course of incubation that facilitates an insight-based solution? Of the various theories that have been advanced, several posit key roles for nonconscious processing. It may be the case, for example, that outside one's conscious awareness, existing knowledge is combined in novel ways or one's initial representation of the problem is replaced and reassembled (Sio & Ormerod, 2009). Alternatively, one may encounter new information that interacts with one's knowledge base, catalyzing a solution in an automatic and seemingly effortless manner—a process termed "opportunistic assimilation" (Seifert, Meyer, Davidson, Patalano, & Yaniv, 1995).

Although the specific mechanisms activated may vary by case or problem type, to the degree insights are produced through nonconscious processing, it is difficult—to the point of impossible, perhaps—for people to observe in full the cognitive operations at play. This does not mean, however, that people cannot attempt to construct theories in this regard, or that people's attempts to make sense of their insights are uninformative or inconsequential. To wit, constructing accounts of how their epiphanies emerged can help people assign meaning to their epiphanies, inform the choices they make subsequently, and chart the course of personal change. As such, the manner in which people describe and interpret their epiphanies carries import, regardless of the veridicality of such accounts.

Building on this observation, I focused my investigation on how people make sense of their epiphanies. As previously noted, in this article, I view epiphanies as insights related to one's self-concept (cf. Miller & C' de Baca, 2001). From this

perspective, epiphanies involve “insights and/or changes in perspective” (McDonald, 2008: 90) through which one sees oneself, one’s past, one’s future, or one’s connection to others in a new light. As such, the insight characterizing an epiphany is self-referential—a feature witnessed in the claim that epiphanies are occasions in which “the Me . . . experienced decided transformation” (McAdams, 1996: 309) and that epiphanies “transform the individual’s concept of self and identity” (McDonald, 2008: 90).

By their nature, epiphanies carry the potential to produce substantial changes in people’s lives. Thus, epiphanies have broad appeal. In business, leaders have credited organizational change initiatives to epiphanies they experienced. For example, the founder of Interface Carpet, Ray Anderson, experienced an epiphany—one so strong that he described it as a “spear in the chest” (Dean, 2007)—that led him to adopt environmental sustainability as a personal value and endorse it as a core mission of his company (Anderson, 1998). Likewise, in literature, epiphanies are immortalized in a host of memorable stories (Langbaum, 1983) just as, in movies, epiphanies drive plotlines and galvanize audiences (Tripp, 2005). For example, the career-related, mission statement provoking breakthrough of Jerry Maguire in the eponymously titled film provides a vivid illustration of an epiphany and speaks to our interest in this seemingly ineffable phenomenon.

From a more psychological perspective, research suggests that epiphanies, like insights more generally, are associated with incubation and non-conscious processing. Specifically, epiphanies occur in response to an existing problem or challenge (i.e., a psychological tension) and arise unexpectedly after the mind has, in some manner, incubated on the focal problem for some length of time (McDonald, 2008; Miller, 2004). Furthermore, the “Aha!” moment associated with epiphanies is comparable with—and perhaps an especially striking illustration of—the “Aha!” experience that can accompany other forms of insight (cf. van Iterson et al., 2017).

Insofar, as epiphanies are linked to nonconscious processing, it stands to reason that people should find it difficult to articulate these processes in detail. Nevertheless, people may seek to understand and reflect on their epiphanies and how they came to arise. Through the research reported here, I examined people’s descriptions of epiphanies surrounding their work and careers with the aim of answering the following research question: *How do people explain, interpret, and draw meaning from their epiphanies?* Or, more simply, *How do people make sense of their epiphanies?*

METHOD

Given that little, if any, previous research in management and organizational studies has addressed the aforementioned research question, I sought to build theory in this area by using an inductive research approach (Corbin & Strauss, 2008; Miles & Huberman, 1994). Although my research consisted primarily of interviews with people who had experienced work- and career-related epiphanies (as detailed in the following paragraphs), I began this project with an exploratory, survey-based study designed to learn more about how people describe the epiphanies they have experienced.

Exploratory Study

I collaborated with a marketing research firm to recruit more than 500 randomly selected individuals for an online survey. On the first page of the survey, individuals read the following passage, which features a definition of epiphanies adopted from McDonald (2008: 90) and endorsed by Cullen (2009).

During the course of their lives, some people experience sudden insights or changes. These moments, often referred to as *epiphanies*, can have a strong and enduring impact on how people see themselves, the people in their lives, their job or career, or some other aspect of their life. More specifically, an epiphany is defined as follows:

A sudden and abrupt insight and/or change in perspective that transforms the individual’s concept of self and identity through the creation of new meaning in the individual’s life.

Have you ever experienced an epiphany (as described and defined above)?

Participants who responded yes to this question proceeded with the survey and completed the epiphany-related questions described in the following paragraphs (See Appendix for survey completion statistics and demographic information). On completing the survey, participants were instructed to think about an epiphany they had experienced and were asked to report what they were doing when the epiphany occurred, the insight(s) and feelings associated with the epiphany, and how they perceived that they changed as a result of the epiphany. Having answered these questions, participants were provided the opportunity to describe up to two more epiphanies they had experienced.

Given that I was interested to see what types of epiphanies people chose to write about, I did not restrict the survey’s focus to work- and career-related epiphanies. As it turned out, however, a sizable

proportion of people wrote about epiphanies involving their work or career. Indeed, 20 percent of the individuals whose reports met my inclusion criteria for data analysis (see the Appendix) detailed one such epiphany. Other reports of epiphanies focused on topics such as personal relationships and unhealthy habits.

Besides demonstrating that people's epiphanies can encompass work- and career-related topics, the verbal reports generated through the exploratory study revealed something else notable. Specifically, in examining each verbal report with respect to the content of the epiphany (i.e., what the epiphany was "about"), I observed that, consistent with the definition of epiphanies provided to the participants, many verbal reports included a *realization* about the nature or meaning of a fundamental aspect of one's life. Interestingly, however, a number of verbal reports focused as much, if not more, on a specific *resolution* associated with the epiphany, as opposed to simply the realization the epiphany produced. These verbal reports discussed, for example, resolutions to change or redirect a particular aspect of one's life (e.g., one's career, relationships, or unhealthy habits) or multiple aspects of one's life (i.e., reorienting one's overall life direction). Table 1 provides illustrative examples of realization-focused verbal reports and resolution-focused verbal reports of epiphanies.

Although it was generally apparent that the resolutions people described stemmed from underlying realizations, the fact that many participants were

drawn to focus their accounts on what their epiphanies had urged them to *do* suggests that epiphanies are not only memorable but also, in many cases, fundamental drivers of personal change. This observation concerning the change-related potency of epiphanies led me to consider through the course of my research interviews and data analysis not only how people describe their epiphanies but also how the features and conditions people ascribe to their epiphanies may account for why epiphanies can have such enduring impact.

Interview-Based Study

Participants and procedure. Because I was interested in building theory around people's reports of work- and career-related epiphanies (given my broader objective of generating theoretical insights for management and organizational scholarship), it was imperative to identify and collect data from a sample of working professionals. To this end, I adopted a purposeful sampling approach (Miles & Huberman, 1994) by contacting through e-mail all members (345) of a university business school's "research collaborative"—a body of alumni who had previously agreed to participate in research studies conducted by the business school's faculty members. The e-mail contained a link to a survey, which provided alumni with the same definition of epiphanies given to research participants in the exploratory study discussed earlier. The survey asked the alumni

TABLE 1
Examples of Realization-Focused and Resolution-Focused Accounts of Epiphanies

Realization-Focused	Resolution-Focused
[I was] in my car, driving to my night job [and] I realized that. . . I wasn't as bad a person as [my mother] had me believe. . . I realized that my job at the time (I was a cocktail waitress at a nightclub) wasn't as bad as I had thought it was. I mean it paid my bills and maybe it wasn't rocket science but it was a good job, one I could be proud of doing well and one I needn't be embarrassed about. I had a better opinion of myself and my prospects.	I knew I always wanted to go to college but I never knew what I wanted to do, so as I was doing one of my chores I had an epiphany that I wanted to get a degree in the healthcare field and help out others and that's what I have done. . . I changed. . . getting my degree and [figured] out my career path for my life.
My high school class was going into the school auditorium for what we thought was an assembly. On the way to my seat I passed my parents sitting there and wondered what they were doing there. As it turned out, a group of us were being surprised by being inducted into the National Honor Society. I don't think before then I had even heard of the National Honor Society. I was proud to be recognized for my academic achievements. I felt "smart." Even though I always had good grades in school, I think this was the first time I felt smart or intelligent. This gave me confidence that I didn't have before.	I was working at home as a customer service representative [and] listening to a customer who was having difficulties in her life. While listening, I felt a strong sensation to begin some form of volunteer work to help others overcome strong emotional situations. I began to attend church regularly, became a member and started doing ministry work in my community.
I had a car accident and was about to get killed but missed the incident by [a] second and realized what life meant after that. I was injured but every second of incident counted. . . every piece of me could have been ruined. I passed that but that big shake changed inside of my like an earthquake. I learned to live better and realized life was precious and shouldn't be taken for granted.	I am considered a workaholic. . . [I was] at the hospital ICU in critical condition after having twins. . . I decided then and there that I would not work as hard as I had all that time (3 jobs) if I walked out of there alive.
	I was at a nursing home where my dad had just passed away. I realized that I didn't want to end up going out feeling remorseful for not having done what I wanted because I was too scared. I decided that I will change my life by enjoying it more and work on getting a job that I love instead of living in the bad dead end job I have.

to indicate whether they had ever experienced an epiphany related to their work, company, or career. If, in fact, they had experienced such an epiphany, the alumni were asked to report what they were doing when the epiphany occurred, the insight(s) and feelings associated with the epiphany, and how they changed as a result of the epiphany. Of the 128 alumni who responded to the survey, 36 indicated that they had experienced a work- or career-related epiphany and provided a description accordingly. The rest of the alumni who responded either indicated that they had not experienced an epiphany associated with their work or career (36) or failed to complete the survey in its entirety (56).

Ultimately, I was able to coordinate and conduct research interviews with 22 of the 36 alumni (12 men, 10 women; age range 31–67) who experienced a work- or career-related epiphany and completed the entire survey (alumni who reported experiencing a work- or career-related epiphany were asked to provide their e-mail address, so they could be contacted for an interview). All but one of these alumni were currently employed, with the majority working in management or business more generally. I interviewed each participating alumnus one time; 16 of these interviews were conducted in person and six by phone. All interviews were recorded and transcribed in full.

During the interviews, four participants discussed not one but two different work- or career-related epiphanies they had experienced. Thus, the analyses and findings reported in the following paragraphs are based on discussions of 26 unique epiphanies surrounding people's work or career. The most recent of these epiphanies occurred approximately 1 year before the study; the oldest occurred 29 years before. On average, the epiphanies occurred approximately 10 years before the study. Table 2 summarizes the content of each epiphany that was discussed and analyzed. As reflected by this table, each epiphany involved a specific realization and most (19 epiphanies) were discussed in line with a specific resolution as well (terms employed in Table 2). Thus, the epiphanies underlying my interview-based study were consistent with an observation surrounding my exploratory study, namely, that people's accounts of their epiphanies often include not only a realization but also a resolution.

Data analysis. In collecting and analyzing my data, I used a modified grounded theory approach (Corbin & Strauss, 2008; Gioia, Corley, & Hamilton, 2013). Consistent with this methodology, I analyzed my data in an iterative fashion, such that my initial reading and coding of the interview transcripts occurred as I was still in the process of collecting data. By iterating between data collection and data analysis, I was able to explore in detail emergent topics and themes. For example, as it became evident that

research participants were reluctant to credit themselves for their own epiphanies, I asked subsequent interviewees specifically about the topic of "credit" to gain more insight in this regard. In this way, although each interview was not driven by an extensive protocol but rather facilitated by a single, overarching question, "Would you please tell me about your epiphany in as much detail as possible?" I was able to account for and probe more deeply into responses common from one interview to the next.

After completing data collection, I read each interview transcript multiple times and examined the data in detail with an eye toward identifying units of data capturing distinct elements associated with people's descriptions of their epiphanies. In doing so, I organized these units of data into categories ("first-order data"). For example, I observed that, across the full set of interviews, research participants discussed how their epiphanies released them from psychological tension. I grouped such statements within a single category.

In the next stage of my analysis, I moved to a higher level of abstraction by assigning names to the categories that emerged in my first-order data. For example, I named the category noted earlier "release of psychological tension." In naming each emergent category, I developed a set of theoretical categories that comprehensively captured all data units relevant to my research question.

In the final stage of my data analysis, I examined the theoretical categories with the aim of identifying aggregate dimensions. In doing so, I recognized that each theoretical category could be classified within one of four dimensions. The first dimension, **Features of Epiphanies**, brings together categories related to the feelings and sensations through which epiphanies are experienced. Participants described their epiphanies through the features reflected in the following categories: "Release of Psychological Tension," "Sudden," and "Strong Emotions." The second dimension, **Mystery**, concerns the cognitive processes underlying epiphanies and includes the theoretical categories "Reassembling" and "Dumbfounding." These categories speak to how the cognitive processes governing epiphanies are difficult to identify and articulate and align with the claim, advanced here, that epiphanies are grounded in nonconscious processing. The third dimension, **Serendipity**, encompasses categories related to an observation noted earlier, namely, that most research participants were reluctant to assign themselves credit for their epiphanies; rather, they tended to credit factors related to the circumstances surrounding their epiphanies. Thus, the theoretical categories pertinent to the serendipity dimension of epiphanies include "Downplaying Credit" and "Circumstances." The fourth dimension, **Readiness**,

TABLE 2
Participants' Work-Related and Career-Related Epiphanies

Participant Code	Epiphany
01F	Realized that by continuing to work long hours with high stress and low pay, she would put undue pressure on her husband and, thus, resolved to leave her job in a research laboratory to work for her family's business
02F	Realized that oil companies should view themselves as business to customer companies rather than business to business companies and resolved to use this insight to reposition her company's strategy and to ultimately revolutionize corporate America
03M	First epiphany: realized that career change was possible and resolved to start his own business with an innovative business model Second epiphany: realized that avoiding layoffs is essential to preserving team culture and resolved not to lay off his employees during an economic downturn
04M	Realized that as a result of greed, people can become self-destructive
05M	Realized that he was on a career path that would not help him understand dimensions of business beyond technical skills and resolved to pursue an MBA
06F	Realized that she wanted to work for her family's business and resolved to do so
07M	Realized the impact of "emotional expensiveness" on performance evaluations and resolved to restructure his career objectives
08M	First epiphany: realized that people differ significantly in their motivation to perform their jobs and that his motivation was highly ambitious compared with others Second epiphany: realized the nature and scope of his own business expertise
09M	Realized that business can be transformative for society and resolved to pursue an MBA to help achieve such transformation
10F	Realized that she needed to make more focused decisions for her work and family and resolved to pursue an MBA
11F	First epiphany: realized that a career in the Air Force was not part of her future and resolved to pursue a different career Second epiphany: realized that seeking to grow and develop one's direct reports was a highly effective leadership philosophy
12F	Realized that she was more interested in how businesses are run than how equipment is designed and resolved to pursue a graduate degree in business rather than in engineering
13F	Realized that her dream job involved the political world and resolved to pursue an internship in Washington D.C.
14M	First epiphany: realized that his current career path would not prove rewarding and resolved to go to America to pursue a graduate degree Second epiphany: realized that achieving success in Silicon Valley is not a technology problem but rather a marketing problem
15F	Realized that she had chosen a job based on the wrong selection criteria and resolved to pursue a new job that matched the type of job she desired most
16M	Realized that the interesting problems of the future are related to biology and resolved to pursue a master's degree in computational biology
17M	Realized that he wanted to pursue a different model of education and resolved to go to America to study engineering
18F	Realized that her company's strategy was not sustainable and that she would not be able to work for the company until retirement as she had planned
19M	Realized that he did not want to continue working in engineering and resolved to pursue an MBA to become a consultant
20F	Realized that she could no longer continue to carry out orders she believed were unethical and resolved to leave her organization and pursue a different job
21M	Realized that work was no longer an outlet for pursuing achievements but solely a means for providing for his family
22M	Realized that he wanted to be a change management consultant and resolved to become one

captures the participants' observation that their epiphanies emerged, in part, because they were open to the possibility of experiencing an epiphany and sufficiently attuned to unfolding events, such that the moments of serendipity associated with epiphanies had the potential to take hold. Thus, this aggregate dimension includes the categories "Openness to Epiphanies" and "Attunement to Unfolding Events."

Table 3 presents the data structure that emerged through the process described earlier and provides

examples of first-order data. The codes accompanying the data excerpts in Tables 2 and 3 and the findings in the following section are participant identification codes (01–22), in which "F" and "M" denote female and male, respectively.

FINDINGS

My findings indicate that people tend to make sense of their work- and career-related epiphanies

TABLE 3
Data Structure

First-Order Data	Theoretical Categories	Aggregate Dimensions
Statements about how epiphanies involve the release of psychological tension <i>I wanted to become more strategic. I just didn't know how, so I had been – that had been flying around my head. . . Then on the other side was my dealings with my clients, and oil and gas was doing well, and I had several things happening. My clients could not hold onto their people, like where tension was a killer. . . those are the types of things that have been running in my brain for some time. So I just didn't – like I said, I didn't know how to put all of – now it seems like, "No duh!" (02F)</i>	Release of psychological tension	Features of epiphanies
Statements about how epiphanies occur suddenly <i>That was a real true changing point for me because all of a sudden I realized what being an expert in the field really meant. (08M)</i>	Sudden	
Statements about how epiphanies involve strong emotions Interviewer: <i>So was it sort of a strong feeling all at once?</i> 01F: <i>Yes, oh yeah. . . It's exciting kind of. It's like I don't have to do this [anymore].</i>	Strong emotions	
Statements about how participants perceived that their epiphanies occurred as their mind reassembled personal experiences in new ways <i>There's a lot of tensions for various reasons and things are noodling around in an inarticulate way and then suddenly it all just comes together. (20F)</i>	Reassembling	Mystery
Cases in which participants struggled to explain what psychological processes contributed to their epiphanies Interviewer: <i>Can you say a little bit more directly about where you think an epiphany like that would come from?</i> 03M: <i>I don't know. That's a – I mean, that's a great question.</i>	Dumbfounding	
Statements about how participants were reluctant to take credit for their epiphanies <i>Well, at some point, you have to do it in your brain, but I don't contribute to myself. I don't think – I would say maybe my daughter did it to me. . . It was the experience of [having] her. (06F)</i>	Downplaying credit	Serendipity
Statements about how participants perceived that their epiphanies arose in the context of certain conditions <i>I think probably a lot of it is for that, for me, was probably working with my counterpart. Seeing this guy. This guy would wake up at five in the morning every morning and would just work so hard and study so hard, and would still be stuck with a situation that was bleak. (09M)</i>	Circumstances	
Statements about how participants perceived that they had an epiphany because they were open to the prospect of experiencing one <i>I guess at the time I was open – really, really open for those insights. . . knowing that I needed to get a job. I needed to see where I'm going and I wanted to have a purpose for myself, to get a job for myself for my life. (22M)</i>	Openness to epiphanies	Readiness
Statements about how participants perceived that they had an epiphany because they were attuned to events that could help produce one <i>I think the importance of reading and just listening and meeting people and talking to different people, I think that all of that coming together I think gives – will create an epiphany. I could sit there and say, "Well, I'm looking at oil and gas. There's no need for me to have coffee with this guy who works – who works in tech or who works in some industry that I'm not – who works in health care." But if there's an opportunity to talk to him or hear him, and there's some inkling of interest or there's something that's like, "Well, this could be interesting," I feel like, "Do it. Go hear people talk." (13F)</i>	Attunement to unfolding events	

through a particular sequence. As detailed in this section, the process of making sense of epiphanies is triggered by the features of epiphanies themselves. The participants in my study described their epiphanies as involving a sudden and emotionally charged release of psychological tension. These features render people's epiphanies meaningful and memorable and, thus, beg the question

of how the epiphanies came into being. Here arises a challenge for those seeking to make sense of their epiphanies. Given that the cognitive underpinnings of epiphanies are largely inscrutable because of their nonconscious origins, people experience a level of dumbfounding in this regard. They surmise only that a psychological process of "reassembling" occurred. In turn, people give thought to a set of factors that

seem, at least by comparison, more amenable to discernment: the conditions people believe ultimately served to produce their epiphanies. Such reflection

leads people to explain the emergence of their epiphanies in terms of an interplay between serendipity and readiness—conditions which, as later discussed, open

FIGURE 1
Making Sense of Epiphanies



new windows into our understanding of cognition in organizations. Figure 1 illustrates the full sequence of making sense of epiphanies detailed in the following paragraphs.

Features of Epiphanies

Consistent with previous scholarly accounts of epiphanies (e.g., McDonald, 2008), the participants in my study perceived that their epiphanies involved a release of psychological tension. For example, as one participant stated, “Well... there was some stress building up around the issue, which maybe is why it was such an epiphany, 'cause it was a way to relieve the stress.” (07M)

In most cases, participants indicated that the psychological tension preceding their epiphanies was longstanding. Consider the following statement.

The tensions had been going on for a long time but it really hadn't occurred to me to just say just the heck with it, because I did like what I did. I liked the people I worked with. There wasn't anything wrong, it was just too much and there was no easy way to make small changes and make a significant change. (20F)

Similarly, another participant (06F) reported that she had long struggled to determine which career to pursue and whether to work for her family's business. Following the birth of her child, she experienced an epiphany that working for her family's business was the right path for her and proceeded to follow that course.

In a few accounts of epiphanies, the psychological tension was described as following from a specific event that produced surprise or confusion which, in turn, was released through the emergence of an epiphany. For example, a woman (11F) serving in the Air Force was told by her commanding officer that because of a medical issue, she would no longer be able to serve in the way she had envisioned. In her words, “I was losing the future that I thought I was gonna have.” In struggling with this revelation, she gave thought to serving the Air Force in alternative capacities. Ultimately, she realized “the [emotional] cost was just not something I was willing to pay” and thus resolved to pursue an altogether different career.

Also consistent with extant literature on epiphanies (e.g., Miller, 2004; Tripp, 2005), the research participants described their epiphanies as sudden. For example, one participant stated, “That was a real true changing point for me because all of a sudden I realized what being an expert in the field really meant (08M).” Similarly, a sense of suddenness (as reflected by the term “spontaneous”) is central to the following account: “Mine was a bit spontaneous.

Even though we can identify some latent things that played into my perspective or context or something, it was quite spontaneous.” (10F)

Participants also described their epiphanies as accompanied by strong emotions. In many cases, participants discussed positive emotions, such as happiness and excitement, surrounding their epiphanies. To illustrate, in the following excerpt from an interview, the epiphany of note is described as both sudden and accompanied by positive emotions.

I think probably when I got pushed into a corner where I had to make a decision, where basically, it was this impending... maternity leave was coming up and I was gonna have to go back to work and so, the panic was building up, because I didn't want to do that. And then I was like, “What am I going to do?” And it just felt—there almost wasn't even a question. It was like, the right answer was, “I go work for my family.” Suddenly, that just seemed like what I wanted to do. And whereas before, I could never get there... It was a feeling... and... just sort of a happiness and a desire to do that. (06F)

In some cases, the positive emotions associated with epiphanies appeared to persist over time. For example, one participant (02F) explained that her epiphany produced such passion in her that she still felt “charged up about it every day”—to the point that she was keen on “revolutionizing corporate America” in line with her epiphany-based vision. Likewise, my data suggest that the strong and often-times positive emotions surrounding epiphanies can serve to imprint an epiphany in one's mind and create what the participant quoted in the following paragraph described as a “defining point.”

All of a sudden I just—it was—it was kind of weird, because it was almost physical to a certain extent. I kind of felt like I could see colors better. That sounds really kinda corny, but... all of a sudden I just got this deep pride in myself that somebody that had – you know, that I admired this much actually cared enough about me to invest his time. So it was – there was a lot going on, and I happen to be a fairly emotional person anyway, so I tend to tie a lot of things to emotion. But it was a very emotional thing, and like I said, that happened [eight years ago] and it's still a defining point in my life that I think about often. (11F)

The strong emotions associated with epiphanies were not always described as positive, however. For example, one research participant (21M) reported that in the midst of prolonged unemployment prompted by an economic downturn, he experienced

an epiphany that, from then on, work would represent solely a means for providing for his family as opposed to a forum for personal achievement—an insight that did not alleviate his distress at the time (“I was certainly not enthusiastic and I wasn’t active and I wasn’t as encouraged”) but rather was in keeping with that distress. Furthermore, in discussing her epiphany-related emotions, another participant (10F) conceded that along with the surprise she experienced in response to her epiphany, which involved the realization that she had to define her priorities in life and begin making career decisions in a manner aligned with those priorities, it felt “a little bit scary to take on something so big.”

Together, the accounts aforementioned depict epiphanies as resolving psychological tension, and thus, presenting solutions to personal challenges. The fact that participants described their epiphanies as sudden and infused with strong emotions aligns with the observation that epiphanies are memorable and impactful (C’ de Baca & Wilbourne, 2004), as well as with research highlighting the impact of sudden and unexpected emotional events (e.g., Ballinger & Rockmann, 2010; Fletcher et al., 2001). Given that epiphanies are experienced through these particular features, it is hardly surprising that they command attention and often endure in memory. This does not mean, however, that experiencing an epiphany provides a thorough understanding of what happened in one’s mind that produced the epiphany. Indeed, as described in the following paragraphs, to make sense of one’s epiphany is to engage with a rather vexing enigma.

Mystery

Epiphanies are an inscrutable phenomenon—an observation central to their mystique (Bidney, 2004; Bien, 2004). Although attempts at articulating the cognitive operations underlying epiphanies can certainly be made, such attempts are rooted in surmises and speculations. When asked to describe what type of psychological processes produced their epiphanies, the participants in my study speculated that a process involving a reassembling of various aspects of their experiences and identity had occurred. Consider, for example, the following statements.

I think that all of the pieces were there and floating around and swimming in my head for a very long time and I just kind of—it’s like a perfect storm gathering, right? I kept collecting all these data points that were making me feel like I’m gonna be onto something. I don’t know what it is. I don’t know when it’s gonna come. I

don’t know but there was just all this stuff was happening, leading up to that moment and the epiphany itself. (02F)

You kind of stumble across a connection that you weren’t specifically looking to do. It wasn’t like you were an archaeologist, and you say, “Okay, I’m gonna be very scientific and dig in this square, and oh, look, I found a bone.” (15F)

As these statements suggest, epiphanies are perceived by those who have experienced them as the result of a process in which various thoughts, concerns, and memories “floating around” in one’s head reassemble themselves, such that one “stumble[s] across a connection.”

Insofar, as epiphanies arise through nonconscious processing, it makes sense that research participants found it difficult to articulate these processes in detail. Quite understandably, in discussing this topic, participants displayed some degree of “dumbfounding” (cf. Haidt, 2012). For example, in discussing a conversation with her boss surrounding her epiphany, one participant (10F) stated: “I don’t know why this particular casual conversation felt so much bigger to me.” Other participants also exhibited dumbfounding. To illustrate:

I don’t know how to describe the moment when I just kind of—it clicked... and that’s what I don’t know. (02F)

I’m not sure. I think a lot about this statement: Luck is, what, 50 percent preparation, and what’s the other 50 percent? Being in the right place at the right time or something. I think an epiphany can certainly result from—I think it’s a lot of factors coming together. I don’t know. (13F)

The fact that epiphanies are difficult to explain lends an air of mystery to them. By their nature, mysteries tend to draw attention and compel curiosity (Alvesson & Kärreman, 2007). Accordingly, it is generally not enough for people to simply shrug their shoulders and refrain from reflecting any further on the genesis of their epiphanies. Instead, the mystery associated with the cognitive operations underlying epiphanies sets the stage for people to devote thought to phenomena that seem more amenable to discernment: the conditions under which they believe their epiphanies were born: “serendipity” and “readiness.”

Serendipity

Although they were the ones who experienced the epiphanies of note, research participants

were, in general, reluctant to credit themselves in full for the epiphanies they experienced. As one participant stated, “Yeah, I don’t know that I would get credit. So, I don’t know if it was the stars aligning or what but something aligned and it just made sense to me.” (01F) Likewise, another stated, “No, I can’t take credit for it; I didn’t make it happen.” (18F)

Rather than crediting only themselves, participants credited the circumstances surrounding their epiphanies as playing a key role. More specifically, participants pointed to factors ranging from their work setting to input provided by colleagues and family members to books they were reading at the time as key contributors to the epiphanies they experienced. The following quote concerning the circumstances surrounding a particular epiphany is illustrative in this regard.

I think about that sometimes. So many things in life are somewhat a product of circumstance. Had I taken a lab job, I don’t know, would I have gotten just totally sick of working in a lab and said, “I just need to do something completely different”? Would I have hit that point, or would I just gotten comfortable with, “This is what I do, so I’m gonna keep doing it”? I don’t know if I had gone that route. I think in making the decision to work at [company name], I think that really got the ball rolling toward that direction. I think that once that happened, I think ultimately, regardless of what position I ended up in, just being exposed to a large company and having so many different parts coming together. (12F)

In many cases, participants pointed to other people as contributors to their epiphanies—and credited those people accordingly. As one participant stated, “Yeah. . . I totally lay all the – all the credit at the foot of my friend. My manager at the time, I mean. It’s totally him.” (11F) Similarly, another participant stated, “I think I would have gotten there through some avenue eventually, but the way it happened, the timing just—it happened faster probably than it would have otherwise just because of my boss getting promoted and all of those pieces coming together.” (12F) Likewise, given that her epiphany arose through a conversation with her boss, participant 10F credited her boss with the epiphany while crediting others as well: “Obviously, there’s the supporting cast. There’s my mom. There’s all kind of things that sort of fed my perspective about what it is to be a mom; what it is to be a wife; what it is to be a woman who works. But I think the initial thing is definitely [my boss].”

One participant offered an especially philosophical and eloquent response in reflecting on

what it means to assign credit in the case of epiphanies.

Why does there need to be credit? . . . I mean, something just is. . . If there’s a blade of grass growing, who gets the credit for that? Is it nature? Is it the person who planted the grass? Is it the wind that blew the grass seed over there? Is it the bird that didn’t eat that particular seed? I mean, is it the rainfall? What gets the credit for it? . . . It’s all of the above. (04M)

Although questioning the very notion of credit itself, this participant’s perspective aligns with the broader finding of note here, namely, participants were prone to view their epiphanies as products of serendipitous circumstances rather than (exclusively) products of their own doing. In viewing their epiphanies as rooted in circumstances that happened to arise, people tend to regard their epiphanies as fortunate or “lucky” and thus worth cherishing (cf. Liu & de Rond, 2016). As one participant stated in reflecting on her epiphany, “Well, damn, that was super lucky, so I’m gonna hold that a little bit near and dear to me, ’cause I feel a little bit lucky that I discovered that.” (15F) Such statements deepen our understanding of why people’s accounts of their epiphanies matter from a change perspective. In particular, these statements suggest that when people believe a self-referential insight has been afforded to them serendipitously, they are inclined to put stock in the insight and to remain steadfast in whatever change efforts they initiate in turn.

Readiness

In one key respect, however, participants did perceive that they played a role in the generation of their epiphanies. Consider, for example, the following quote, in which the research participant credits someone else for her epiphany but also points to her own “open-mindedness” and the fact that she was “ready for it” as playing a role in the generation of the epiphany.

I give credit to myself for open-mindedness. I give credit to [name] for bringing the pearl. I mean she was the straw, right, that she was the one thing, she tipped it for me. So, I really do give her the credit for bringing it all together. I was just the open receptacle ready, ready for it, right? It’s like when people find God sort of thing, probably not that profound but that’s what it was. (02F)

Just as one can be prepared or “ready” to interpret or categorize physical objects in line with one’s

experiences and expectations (Bruner, 1957), so too does it appear that an epiphany arises when one has readied oneself to receive its emergence. My data point to two interconnected aspects of readiness, each seemingly critical to helping people generate epiphanies. First, based on my data, people must be open to the prospect of experiencing an epiphany (and the transformational changes that may come with it) for an epiphany to occur. Although epiphanies release people from psychological tension, for various reasons noted in the following paragraphs, people may be resistant to the very idea of experiencing an epiphany. Thus, epiphanies may prove elusive not because one is incapable of producing them but rather because some aspect of one's identity or self-concept is standing guard at the gate, preventing personal transformation from occurring.

This intriguing possibility emerged early in my study through an especially revealing statement. Specifically, one participant remarked, "I also know that there are a lot of epiphanies that I would not be prepared to have. That someone else in the same situation would probably get." (05M) This statement suggests that, under the same circumstances (and given a similar psychological tension), others might experience an epiphany because of greater openness. Additional participants offered similar comments in this regard. For example, one participant observed that epiphanies follow from "being curious about what's next, what else – in other words, not settling down, I guess." (17M) This participant elaborated as follows.

The moment you start—you feel comfortable where you are, just because you don't have any more ambition or you are close enough to retirement just to say, "I'm going to work a couple more years and then retire," when you stop looking, I think you stop having those processes that end up in an epiphany.

As this quote suggests, one reason people may be averse to—and thus unlikely to experience—epiphanies is that they do not see a need for them. When one is either close to retirement or resolute in one's career path, one may be uninterested in experiencing a work- or career-related epiphany. Furthermore, as suggested by another participant, some people may not have a "positive attitude" toward epiphanies.

I think a lot of people miss epiphanies because of their lack of willingness to be open to them. . . So I think, unfortunately, maybe people miss a lot of epiphanies that could actually be rather beneficial to them 'cause they're just not taking a positive attitude to them existing. (15F)

Some people's lack of a positive attitude toward epiphanies may stem from the fact that identity-level change can be disconcerting or threatening—qualities likely to limit one's openness to such change. As one participant observed, experiencing an epiphany is "a matter of accepting if we do change or if we just hold it back for the sake of status quo." (22M) In other words, as this participant suggests, the potential for experiencing an epiphany may be ever-present—provided one is psychologically prepared to reorient one's view of self. With an open attitude toward epiphanies, it might be simply "a matter of seeing it and oh, voila!" (22M)

Second, my data suggest that epiphanies are facilitated when one is highly attuned to ongoing events, including one's affective reactions to those events. Without such attunement, one may dismiss or trivialize events that could otherwise serve to create moments of serendipity. The following statement is illustrative in this regard.

If I had been more aware of my job satisfaction and the satisfaction of my employees and the current growth status of the company, I might have realized earlier on that this isn't really working. I might have realized that even if I wasn't really unhappy at work I had more potential in this job to be unhappy than happy. I was just plugging along, going about day-by-day, here's the plan; so if I'd been more aware I think that it would have been different. (18F)

This statement suggests that although participant 18F ultimately experienced an epiphany, she believes that her epiphany might have been expedited had she attended more thoroughly to the details of her day-to-day work life and her feelings concerning them. More specifically, it appears from this statement that this participant may have been resistant to reflecting upon or probing in depth matters related to her job (dis)satisfaction, thus holding a potential epiphany at bay – at least temporarily.

To develop greater attunement toward unfolding events, it may be useful to pursue and embrace novel experiences—a possibility aligned with scholarly observations on exploration and travel (e.g., de Botton, 2002) and suggested by my research participants. As one observed:

It's about filling up the backpack with stuff. So why would an engineer learn any kind of poetry? Or why should kids that will work in robotics learn good novels? Why should a business person, or should a financial guy read about ethics, or read about Plato, or read about philosophy in general? I think it's about putting things in place for epiphanies to happen. (05M)

Ultimately, however, whether one's surroundings are novel or mundane, attuning oneself to ongoing events begins with a willingness to accept events for what they are, as opposed to ignoring, dismissing, or prematurely categorizing such events. On this point, a research participant discussed the value of meditation as a vehicle for attuning oneself to unfolding events and, in turn, producing epiphanies.

And I found all that [meditation training] very helpful, and it creates a mental discipline. It creates an openness, an open mind that doesn't fight things off so much, and if you are fighting something off, you sort of say, okay, why am I fighting? What am I not looking at? What am I afraid of here? (04M)

As this quote indicates, some people may be “afraid” to focus in depth on certain aspects of who they are and what is happening around them. This participant suggested that by adopting techniques designed to cultivate greater awareness—techniques that defuse the need for defensiveness—people may ready themselves to receive and accept epiphanies. Interestingly, this participant's use of techniques in this regard was catalyzed by the very epiphany he experienced, namely, that people can be vulnerable to self-destruction and, thus, can fail to perceive and benefit from the possibilities life holds.

The value of attuning oneself to unfolding events as an avenue toward achieving epiphanies becomes apparent when one considers that, unless they are granted significant attention and import, the events one witnesses or participates in are unlikely to reshape aspects of one's self-concept. In this sense, it is, perhaps, less accurate to say that serendipity occurs when the circumstances are “right” than it is to say that, with sufficient openness and attunement, certain circumstances take on the potential for creating moments of serendipity. By illuminating this prospect, the epiphany-related accounts described here point toward an interplay between serendipity and readiness, such that the latter heightens the potentiality or potency of the former. As discussed in the following paragraphs, this interplay—and several other observations stemming from my findings—carries theoretical and practical implications for our understanding of epiphanies, insights, and problem-solving in organizations.

DISCUSSION

Although overshadowed in a work world touting the merits of rational analysis (March, 1994), many aspects of human thinking are governed by processes occurring outside people's conscious awareness. Thus, people experience mental phenomena steeped in mystery. Through the research reported here, I explored how people make sense of the byproducts of seemingly ineffable processes unfolding within their own minds. In doing so, I focused on the phenomenon of work- and career-related epiphanies, a personally meaningful and frequently memorable form of insight. Taken together, my findings carry a number of implications worth considering.

Theoretical Implications

Interpretation and attribution. To begin, my findings provide cause to reconsider whether the limitations of introspection are as problematic as often assumed. Because of the fact that much thinking occurs outside conscious awareness (see Kahneman, 2011), people cannot observe many of their own cognitive operations directly and thoroughly (George, 2009; Pratt & Crosina, 2016). As such, research incorporating people's verbal reports of thinking, decision-making, and problem-solving provides, at best, incomplete descriptions of psychological processes (Hofmann & Wilson, 2010; Nisbett & Wilson, 1977). Nevertheless, the research reported here suggests that our inability to observe and articulate key aspects of psychological functioning may be adaptive in certain ways. Although some have suggested that operations inaccessible to introspection are useful for their efficiency and need not be observed to serve us well (Bargh & Chartrand, 1999), the present research suggests that such operations may be valuable for the mysteries they engender. By their nature, mysteries compel our attention and add resonance and import to insights that might otherwise seem more pedestrian. In the case of epiphanies, the mystery of what has happened “behind the scenes” to prompt a sudden, emotionally charged release of psychological tension nudges people toward considering the origins of their epiphanies by reflecting on the conditions that led to their generation. Not only is this process of making sense of something mysterious and remarkable conducive to enshrining an epiphany in memory but it also turns out to serve people well by providing them gratitude and perceptions of good fortune.

Underlying such feelings and perceptions is that, in making sense of their epiphanies, people are drawn to view their epiphanies as constructed as

Author's voice:

Has the author ever had an epiphany?



much, if not more, by their environment than by their own doing. This observation is notable because it runs somewhat counter to existing accounts of attribution in management and psychology (for a review, see Harvey, Madison, Martinko, Crook, & Crook, 2014). Especially in American and other Western populations, when favorable personally relevant outcomes occur, people are inclined to credit themselves for such outcomes (Bradley, 1978; Mezulis et al., 2004; Shepperd, Malone, & Sweeny, 2008). That is, in response to a successful event (e.g., resolving a longstanding problem), people impute causality primarily in terms of their own attributes and assets as opposed to forces or factors beyond themselves. In the case of an epiphany, however, people tend to point toward any number of situational factors—ranging from their job circumstances, to the way they were raised, to people they know—to account for the epiphany they experienced. Remarkably then, people's attributions deviate from a commonly witnessed pattern: that people tend to “underestimate the role of luck (e.g., randomness and situational factors) in observed outcomes” (Liu & de Rond, 2016: 425).

In part, the attributions people make about their epiphanies might be understood by the connection between epiphanies and nonconscious processing. More specifically, people may be unlikely to feel a sense of control associated with psychological phenomena when they cannot witness the processes underlying them, and thus, they may grant attention and import to what *can* be observed and reflected upon, namely, the external circumstances that occurred in tandem with their epiphanies. At the same time, research indicates that one need not perceive a sense of control to locate the origin of events within oneself (Weiner, 1985). For example, one may attribute success on a performance-related task to one's own intelligence—a factor largely outside one's control (cf. Weiner, 2010). Theoretically, then, it should be possible and perhaps even likely for people to view their epiphanies as an internally generated, yet largely uncontrollable, phenomenon. Nevertheless, people's attributions for their own epiphanies lean toward external causes.

People's reluctance to attribute their epiphanies to an internal locus raises the possibility that, for some psychological events, perhaps especially those emanating from nonconscious processes, it may be either more natural, more rewarding, or both to locate the genesis of the event primarily in forces beyond oneself. This not only provides a counterpoint to the self-serving bias but also suggests that, in some cases, people may be more drawn to humility than to self-aggrandizement—an observation that dovetails with the field's expanding appreciation for experiences

involving emotions such as elevation and awe that lead people to gain heightened wonderment for the world (see Yaden, Haidt, Hood, Vago, & Newberg, 2017).

Readiness and problem-solving. As my findings indicate, people believe that their epiphanies occurred not only because of serendipitous circumstances but also because they were open to experiencing them and attuned to unfolding events that carried the potential to produce them. The fact that people make sense of their epiphanies in this way (as a phenomenon fostered through *readiness*) is noteworthy for several reasons.

First, my findings surrounding readiness suggest that personal change can occur through underappreciated, yet potent, pathways. In many cases, personal change is preceded by a lengthy period of deliberation. For example, in studying people who relinquished previous social identities (e.g., ex doctors, ex police officers, and ex nuns), Ebaugh (1988: 88) found that, before their transition, most people proceeded in “a very deliberate and rational fashion, often making lists of possible alternatives and itemizing the costs and rewards of each alternative role.” Personal (or career) change of this form is experienced as agentic and volitional; one chooses to make a change or, at the very least, one is well aware of certain factors leading to the initiation of a change effort. By contrast, as detailed here, in the case of epiphanies, people believe that the impetus for change did not arise through deliberation but rather through a combination of serendipity and readiness. Consequently, people do not so much feel as though they elected to make a change as they perceive that a change bestowed itself upon them. This perception speaks to why vague admonitions to the tune of “When the time is right, you'll know” may have underappreciated merits. Such advice may steer one away from a more deliberative approach to change and set in place certain conditions associated with epiphanies, such as heightened openness to the prospect of experiencing an epiphany.

Second, my findings on the role of readiness in the creation of epiphanies may inform our understanding of insight-based problem-solving. As discussed earlier, insight is often conceived of as a process in which the nonconscious mind arrives at a new and useful representation that facilitates solving an existing problem. Implicit to previous research in this area, which has been conducted mainly through laboratory experiments using tasks such as the “nine-dot problem” (e.g., MacGregor et al., 2001), is the assumption that people are keen on solving the problem of note. That is, such research is grounded in the premise that problem solvers are motivated to reach an insight (see Chu & MacGregor, 2011 for a

review of research on insight problem-solving). The findings reported here serve notice that, in the case of problems associated with people's psychological tensions, this premise may be misplaced. As suggested by my findings, people are not always ready for an epiphany to arrive. Consequently, the processes associated with producing one may not unfold. In some cases, the same may be true when it comes to generating other insights associated with one's work-related problems. For example, whether one is struggling with a difficult assignment, seeking to resolve a seemingly intractable disagreement between one's colleagues, or wrestling with an ethical dilemma, experiencing an insight is not without potential liabilities. Arriving at an insightful solution for a difficult assignment may elevate one's reputation in a way one is not prepared for. Resolving a conflict through an insightful strategy could create a connection—and, in time, an alliance—between two of one's adversaries. Recognizing how to approach an ethical dilemma through a sudden burst of "moral insight" (Zhang et al., 2018) could create complications if one's imaginative solution runs counter to organizational norms.

As these observations suggest, the psychological operations underlying insight may not operate very effectively when one is concerned about the consequences likely to follow if one solves a given problem. It may, therefore, be the case that, at a nonconscious level, some problems (i.e., those one is fully committed to solving) receive a more flexible or fluent set of problem representations and conceptual combinations than others. This would imply that achieving insightful solutions to challenging problems is not simply a matter of pursuing incubation effects (e.g., by taking breaks from work tasks). Rather, generating insight-based solutions may involve reflecting upon one's personal relationship with the problem of note and, as needed, identifying ways to allay one's concerns about the potential consequences associated with experiencing an insight.

Reflection of this form differs from the type of "preparation" scholars have long ascribed to the process of creative problem-solving (Lubart, 2001; Wallas, 1926). As often theorized, the process by which insights and creative ideas are generated begins by defining the problem, gathering information systematically, and thinking deliberately and laboriously for an oftentimes lengthy period of time (Amabile & Pratt, 2016; Sadler-Smith, 2015). By contrast, my research participants perceived that they set the stage for their epiphanies not so much through systematic planning and lengthy deliberation but rather through the relinquishing of certain concerns or beliefs that had been hindering their ability to modify aspects of their self-concept. This

observation suggests that, at times, achieving insights may be less about gaining new information and more about releasing one's grasp on identity-level tensions. That is, until one is ready to reconsider, abate, or relinquish personal concerns attached to reaching a solution, one's mind may resist formulating an insight.

Third, my findings surrounding readiness—particularly those speaking to the importance of staying attuned to unfolding events—connect to and stand to reorient the "opportunistic assimilation" perspective on insight (Seifert et al., 1995). As noted earlier, this perspective maintains that insights arise when people fortuitously encounter cues or events that catalyze their mind's engagement with a particular problem. Building on this perspective, my findings suggest that, to enhance one's prospects of reaching insights in this way, one should not simply focus on pursuing novel experiences that carry the potential to trigger insights. Rather, one should also engage with existing circumstances and surroundings as mindfully as possible. Most likely, there is nothing hallowed about the particular cues or events one encounters that catalyze an insight. Conceivably, many cues and events may carry significance or prove informative when one approaches the world with an open and curious mind—a mind that is ready to perceive the world as an ally for one's problem-solving efforts. As suggested earlier, a potentially useful practice in this regard is mindfulness meditation—a technique designed to enhance one's attunement to unfolding events and reduce the degree to which one is inclined to judge, resist, or block these events (Hölzel, Lazar, Gard, Schuman-Olivier, Vago, & Ott, 2011). More generally, these observations suggest that achieving insights at work is a matter of discerning and embracing nuances in everyday events.

LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH DIRECTIONS

The research reported here required individuals to provide retrospective accounts of their epiphanies. In some cases, these epiphanies occurred years ago, raising questions about the accuracy of participants' memories. Through future research, scholars could attempt to capture people's accounts of their epiphanies in more of a real-time fashion. Although doing so might prove challenging, it is possible that, with sufficient time and a large enough population aware of and agreeable to the research objective, researchers could meet with people shortly after they experience epiphanies, thus examining how they make sense of their epiphanies as closely as possible to their occurrence. This approach would also enable researchers to examine something my data cannot

speak to directly, namely, whether some epiphanies are ultimately dismissed or turn out to be “mistaken” in some way. Because discredited epiphanies may be less memorable than those underlying the reports central to my study, experience-sampling techniques (cf. Scollon, Prieto, & Diener, 2003) may be needed to document such epiphanies and to determine whether the process through which people make sense of them differs in some way from the one described here.

On the reverse side, research is needed to deepen our understanding of the consequences of epiphanies that do, in fact, prove memorable and enduring. Although the research reported here centered on epiphanies people recalled years after experiencing them, the attitudinal and behavioral consequences stemming from epiphanies would be well worth investigating more systematically—perhaps, especially in the case of work- and career-related epiphanies. Here, researchers could examine whether and how experiencing an epiphany tied to one’s work or career influences one’s level of job and career satisfaction, organizational and occupational commitment, co-worker relationship quality, and overall level of job performance. Documenting the consequences of epiphanies in this regard would spotlight the practical significance of epiphanies for organizations and underscore the value of pursuing and achieving epiphanies for organizational members.

Pursuing this line of research could also open the door for some interesting comparisons. For example, scholars could examine whether some of the factors aforementioned (e.g., job and career satisfaction) are influenced by whether one’s path toward one’s current job or career involved an epiphany versus a more systematic process of deliberation. Given that people often view their epiphanies as fortunate or “lucky,” the sense of gratitude surrounding an epiphany might engender positive attitudes toward one’s job or career. Likewise, insofar epiphanies are experienced as occurring, to some degree, through forces beyond oneself, it could be the case that people who have changed jobs or careers because of epiphanies feel less stress or regret than others—and, thus, have more psychological resources available as they perform their work. Such possibilities call for empirical investigation.

Taking a different tack, researchers could explore whether some individuals are more likely than others to experience epiphanies (work-related or otherwise). Possibly, some individuals are more open than others to change and, thus, more apt to experience epiphanies. In testing this possibility, researchers could use survey-based methods to account for the potential role of factors such as openness to experience (McCrae & Costa, 1997) and psychological essentialism (Bastian

& Haslam, 2006) in accounting for individual differences in epiphany frequency.

Another important question is whether epiphanies can be cultivated strategically by individuals keen on either personally experiencing an epiphany or intentionally attempting to impart an epiphany unto others. To some degree, my research and the discussion surrounding it suggests practices associated with the former possibility. As noted, to the degree epiphanies are premised on readiness, people may be able to coax epiphanies by examining themselves, their circumstances, and their surroundings as curiously and mindfully as possible to root out whatever change-related reservations they may carry and to transform otherwise mundane environments into sources of serendipity. But what about sparking epiphanies in others? For organizational leaders, executive coaches, motivational speakers, therapists, and others, inculcating epiphanies might be seen as a touchstone achievement within one’s work. And yet, research has said little about whether and how one can influence or enlighten others in this fashion (but see Cullen, 2009, for a notable exception). Given my findings, it stands to reason that one would need to verify or create in others a readiness for change before one’s epiphany-inducing techniques could gain traction. This suggests that producing epiphanies in others may involve practices that “dismantle [one’s] identity” (Van Maanen, 1978: 33) or “break down meaning” (Pratt, 2000: 456), such that the individuals one has targeted for epiphanies begin to seek new forms of identity or new sources of meaning in their lives (see also Armenakis, Harris, & Mossholder, 1993, for additional organizational strategies for enhancing readiness).

Additional investigation of the attribution-related aspects of epiphanies may also be warranted. In particular, researchers could probe further into why people downplay credit for the epiphanies they experienced. As suggested here, one reason people locate the causal locus of their epiphanies primarily outside themselves is that doing so cultivates gratitude and perceptions of good fortune. Other possibilities in this regard merit consideration as well. For example, in attributing their epiphanies to external causes, people may feel less pressure or regret as they engage in an epiphany-based personal change effort. That is, feeling as though one did not have a choice in the matter may reduce cognitive dissonance if change proves more difficult than one envisioned.

My findings also spotlight more macro directions for future research. As management scholars have observed, in some cases, organizational change occurs in radical ways (Plowman, Baker, Beck, Kulkarni, Solansky, & Travis, 2007; Weick & Quinn, 1999). These “quantum changes” (Miller & Friesen, 1982) are

analogous to epiphanies in that they occur suddenly and can have enduring consequences. In some cases, the connections between organization-level quantum changes and epiphanies may be more than analogical. For example, a senior executive may experience an epiphany that leads to a quantum-like organizational change effort, such as Ray Anderson's reorientation of Interface Carpet toward environmentally sustainable practices noted earlier.

Just as intriguingly, the reverse may also hold true, that is, quantum change in an organization may trigger epiphanies among organizational members. For some organizational members, quantum change is likely to create psychological tension, especially when the nature or motivation of the organization's change agenda is not immediately apparent (Sonenshein, 2010). In some cases, this tension may lead members to reconstruct not only their view of the organization but also of themselves and, thus, lead to epiphanies. Individuals who are highly identified with their organizations would seem likely candidates in this regard, given that these individuals define themselves, in part, based on their organizational membership (Ashforth, Harrison, & Corley, 2008). For someone high in organizational identification, the perception that one's organization has changed substantially may imply that, in some manner, one's personal identity has changed as well. Through further research, scholars could investigate these and related possibilities surrounding cross-level linkages between epiphanies and organizational change.

Finally, given their rarity and profundity and emotional resonance, epiphanies are an "extreme case" of psychological experiences associated with nonconscious processing. The benefit of studying extreme cases lies in the potential for gaining deep and vivid insight into the focal phenomenon (Pratt, 2009). With that said, it remains an open question whether—or to what degree—the findings reported here inform our understanding of how people make sense of other nonconsciously based phenomena. It could be the case that some elements of my findings, such as people's reluctance to credit themselves for their epiphanies, may hold to some degree for many judgments and solutions that emerge nonconsciously. Other elements may be unique to epiphanies. The observation that epiphanies resolve psychological tension is a candidate in this regard. Compared with epiphanies, other phenomena tied to nonconscious processing (e.g., intuitions or gut feelings – see Sadler-Smith, 2016) are perhaps less associated with resolving psychological tension than with facilitating decision-making and solving assigned problems. By comparing people's accounts of a variety of nonconsciously based phenomena, researchers could assess the generalizability of my findings for

our understanding of how people make sense of nonconscious processes and their outcomes.

CONCLUSION

Through the research reported here, I found that although epiphanies arise through nonconscious processes, people can, nevertheless, make sense of them in a moving and meaningful manner. In particular, I found that, in reflecting on their work- and career-related epiphanies, people believe that once they opened themselves to the prospect of personal transformation and attuned themselves to unfolding events, they received their epiphanies through moments of serendipity. Collectively, my findings point toward potentially critical, although undertheorized, mechanisms underlying—and at times, inhibiting—the process of problem-solving and reveal avenues through which people may increase their potential for achieving epiphanies and insights more generally.

In closing, a final point bears noting. The power of epiphanies lies not only in events and cognitive operations that have already unfolded and methods of making sense that have already transpired. Regardless of whether one has experienced an epiphany, the very existence of epiphanies in the world serves notice that, at an unexpected hour, we may be awakened "from the sleep of ordinary life" (Harding, 1986: 2) and something new and revelatory will become clear. In the end, this is the most seductive aspect of epiphanies of all—that, just possibly, if we are ready to receive one, this is the day one will arrive.

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APPENDIX

Exploratory Study: Methodological Details

In total, 524 individuals opened the survey and 266 answered yes to the question determining eligibility. Of these individuals, 119 did not complete the survey in its entirety and 28 individuals provided inadequate or nonsensical reports of their epiphanies (e.g., one participant's full description of an epiphany was "OK"). All of these individuals were excluded from the data analysis.

In addition, 20 individuals provided reports of experiences they perceived as supernatural or otherworldly (e.g., "I was hit by the Holy Spirit. . . I started speaking in tongue, crying, laughing, smiling and singing for the next 3 days"). Given my interest in epiphanies linked to psychological and social phenomena as opposed to perceived supernatural or mystical experiences, I excluded these individuals from my ultimate examination of the data unless they reported more than one epiphany, at least one of which did not involve a perceived supernatural experience.

In sum, the data used in my exploratory study were based on the responses of 104 individuals—those who answered yes to the epiphany-related eligibility question, completed the entire survey, and provided at least one comprehensible, theoretically relevant verbal report of an epiphany. Reflecting the demographic characteristics of the marketing research firm's participant pool, the average age of the 104 individuals was 50, 79 percent were female, 46 percent had received a bachelor's degree or higher, and 60 percent were currently employed (occupations included positions in business, management, and health care, among others).

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